A CLIENT & CLINICIAN WORKBOOK

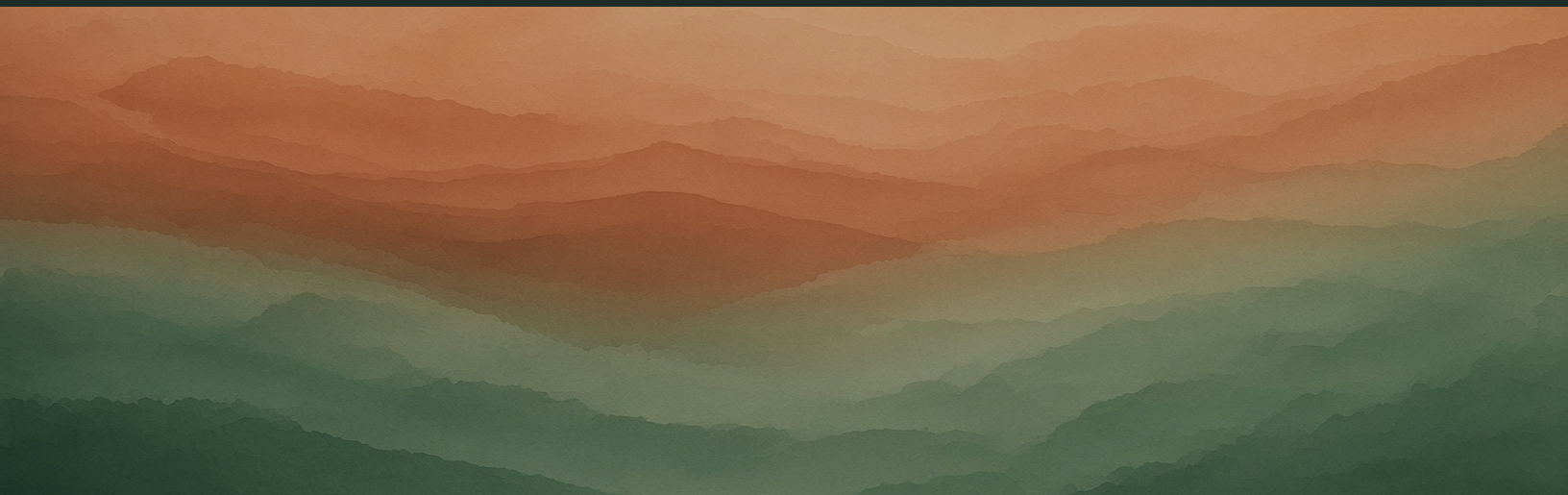
Caring for Me, Too

Letting go of control, caretaking and over-responsibility, and coming back to your own life

A psychoeducation workbook on codependency: detachment with love, reacting less, releasing control, stepping off the drama triangle, self-worth, acceptance and grief, feelings and anger, clear communication, goals and support.

Jessica Prosser, LPC | Anchored Inside

Based on concepts from Melody Beattie, Codependent No More: How to Stop Controlling Others and Start Caring for Yourself (Hazelden, 1987; 2nd ed. 1992). An independent summary in original wording; not affiliated with or endorsed by the author or publisher.



PART OF THE ANCHORED INSIDE WORKBOOK SERIES

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Based on concepts from Melody Beattie, Codependent No More (1987, 1992). Independent summary; not endorsed by author or publisher.

01

SECTION 1

Before You Begin

This workbook is about turning some of the care you give so freely back toward yourself.

Many people who pick up a book about codependency are exhausted. They have spent years worrying about someone else: a partner who drinks, a struggling adult child, a parent in crisis, a friend who always seems to be falling apart. They have tried to help, then tried harder. Somewhere along the way, their own life went quiet.

Writer and counselor Melody Beattie described this pattern in her 1987 book *Codependent No More*, drawing on her own recovery and her work with families affected by addiction. Her central message is simple and radical: we cannot control other people, and we do not have to. We can stop organizing our lives around someone else's choices and start caring for ourselves. This workbook walks through her ideas in plain, original language, with space to reflect.

KEY IDEA

What this workbook offers

- A clear, non-blaming language for patterns that may feel automatic.
- Practical tools for detaching, reacting less and letting go of control.
- Ways to notice rescuing and step out of the drama triangle.
- Reflection prompts, short practices and key ideas you can return to.

TRY THIS

How to use it

- Go slowly. One section at a time is plenty.
- Write freely. The prompts are invitations, not tests.
- Skip what does not fit. Not every idea will match your story.

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TRY THIS (CONT.)

- If you have a therapist or a support group, bring what you notice there.

SAFETY

Going gently, and staying safe

Looking honestly at a painful relationship can stir up grief, anger and fear. That is a sign something matters, not a sign of failure. If you feel flooded, pause, feel your feet on the floor and look around the room you are in now. If you are in danger from someone in your home, contact the National Domestic Violence Hotline (1-800-799-7233) or local emergency services. If you are in crisis or thinking about harming yourself, call or text **988** (Suicide and Crisis Lifeline, U.S.). This workbook is educational and is not a substitute for therapy.

KEY IDEA

Who this workbook is for

- Partners, parents, adult children and friends of someone struggling with addiction or mental illness.
- People who notice they over-give, over-function or lose themselves in relationships.
- Anyone who grew up in a home where their own needs came last.
- Therapists looking for a structured, client-friendly companion to Beattie's ideas.

KEY IDEA

A word about faith and groups

Beattie's approach grew out of Al-Anon and Twelve Step recovery, and she often speaks of a Higher Power. You are welcome to take that language literally, translate it into your own spiritual frame, or set it aside. The practical ideas here stand on their own.

PAUSE AND NOTICE

As you begin, whose life have you been living most closely? Where are you in it?

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02

SECTION 2

What Codependency Is

Not a label for who you are, but a description of where your attention has gone.

Beattie offers a working definition: a codependent person is someone who has let another person's behavior affect them deeply, and who has become preoccupied with controlling that behavior. The other person might be dealing with addiction, mental illness, chronic irresponsibility or simply a very different temperament. The focus here is not on them. It is on how their behavior has come to shape your thoughts, feelings and days.

The word first emerged in addiction treatment centers, to describe family members whose lives had been reshaped by living with someone who drank or used. Over time, professionals noticed the same patterns in people with no addiction in the family at all, often people who grew up in homes with unspoken rules about feelings, problems and needs.

KEY IDEA

Different ways of seeing it

- Some clinicians describe codependency as a set of learned patterns that keep a person from expressing feelings and needs openly.
- Others see it mainly as a normal reaction to living with people who are hard to live with.
- Some treat it as a condition that can worsen without attention, while others are wary of calling it an illness.
- Beattie's own conclusion is practical: whatever we call it, it hurts, and recovery is possible.

Codependency is not a formal diagnosis, and it is not the same as caring deeply. Love, loyalty and helpfulness are good things. The pattern becomes a problem when caring turns into managing, when your sense of okay-ness depends on someone else's choices, and when your own needs keep sliding to the bottom of the list.

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REFLECTION

Who are you most worried about right now? How much of your day do those worries take?

When that person is doing well, how do you feel? When they are not?

What have you stopped doing, or stopped wanting, while focused on them?

TRY THIS

A simple tracking week

For seven days, notice each time your mood shifts because of what someone else did or did not do. Jot down a word or two. You are not trying to change anything yet, only to see the pattern clearly.

- What happened?
- What did I feel, and how strongly, on a scale of one to ten?
- What did I do next?

PAUSE AND NOTICE

Whose behavior affects your mood most? What would change if it didn't?

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03

SECTION 3

Common Characteristics

These patterns were learned, often for very good reasons. They can also be unlearned.

Beattie lists a wide range of traits that people in codependent patterns often recognize. Having them does not make anyone bad, weak or broken. Most began as ways of surviving a situation that felt out of control. The groupings below are a paraphrased sample, not a checklist for diagnosis.

CARETAKING AND WORTH

Caretaking. Feeling responsible for other people's feelings, choices and wellbeing; anticipating needs; saying yes when we mean no; feeling safest when giving. **Low self-worth.** Blaming ourselves, rejecting compliments, feeling we are never quite enough.

INNER PATTERNS

Repression. Pushing feelings and thoughts away out of fear or guilt. **Obsession.** Thinking endlessly about other people and their problems, checking, worrying, losing sleep. **Denial.** Telling ourselves things are not as bad as they are, or that tomorrow will be different.

CONTROL AND RELIANCE

Controlling. Trying to manage events and people through advice, guilt, pressure or helplessness. **Dependency.** Looking to other people for happiness and fearing being alone. **Lack of trust.** In ourselves, our feelings and our decisions, or in others.

RELATING

Poor communication. Blaming, threatening, hinting or saying what we think others want to hear. **Weak boundaries.** Tolerating more and more, then exploding. **Anger.** Feeling scared or guilty about anger, or swallowing it until it leaks out. **Closeness.** Difficulty feeling present or relaxed in intimate

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RELATING (CONT.)

moments.

Why the patterns persist

Beattie notes that these patterns tend to grow over time if left alone: worry deepens, life narrows and exhaustion sets in. The good news is that the same is true of recovery. Each small act of self-care makes the next one a little easier. The aim is not to stop caring, but to start including yourself.

REFLECTION

Which group of traits describes you most? Where do you think you learned it?

What did this pattern protect you from, when it began?

What is it costing you now?

PAUSE AND NOTICE

Which of these patterns felt most familiar? Which one would you most like to soften?

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04

SECTION 4

Detachment with Love

Letting each person carry their own life, including you.

Detachment is one of the most misunderstood ideas in recovery. It is not cold withdrawal, giving up, pretending not to care or cutting people off. Beattie describes it instead as releasing ourselves, with love, from entanglement in another person's problems and responsibilities.

Detachment rests on a few plain truths. Each adult is responsible for their own life. We cannot solve problems that are not ours to solve. Worry does not help. When we stop absorbing the consequences of someone else's choices, they have the chance to face those consequences and to grow. And we get our own life back.

KEY IDEA

What detachment is, and is not

- **It is** keeping our hands off what is not ours, and tending to what is.
- **It is** letting people be who they are, and letting go of the outcome.
- **It is** living as fully as we can today, even if a problem remains unsolved.
- **It is not** withdrawing love, giving the silent treatment or punishing.
- **It is not** pretending the problem does not exist or that we have no feelings about it.

Detachment is both a decision and a skill. Some days we can do it warmly. Other days the best we can manage is physical distance or a closed door. Beattie suggests starting where we are. Detaching in love is ideal, but detaching at all is a start, and over time the love can return.

TRY THIS

Asking the detachment question

When you feel pulled toward someone else's problem, pause and ask:

- Whose problem is this, really?

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TRY THIS (CONT.)

- What part, if any, is mine to do?
- What would happen if I did only my part, and stopped there?
- What could I do for myself right now instead?

REFLECTION

What scares you most about letting someone face their own consequences?

When have you detached before, even briefly? What happened?

PAUSE AND NOTICE

What is one problem you have been carrying that does not belong to you?

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05

SECTION 5

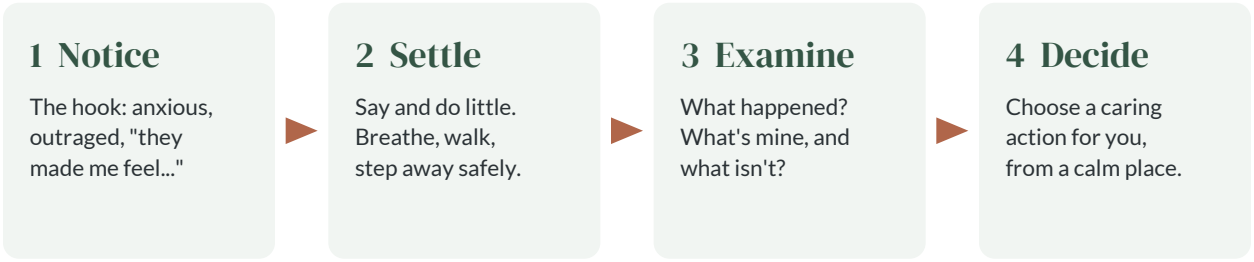
Reacting Less

You do not have to be blown about by every wind.

Reacting is part of being human. The trouble comes when our reactions are so fast and so strong that they run our lives. Many people in codependent patterns live on high alert, ready for the next emergency. A sharp word, an unanswered text or a slammed door sets off a chain of panic, anger, guilt or frantic action.

Beattie observes that we often react because we are anxious, because we feel bad about ourselves, because we think things should be different, or simply because reacting is what we have always done. When we react, we hand our power to whatever we are reacting to. Learning to pause gives it back.

FIGURE 1 FROM REACTING TO RESPONDING



THE SHIFT from automatic reaction · to a pause · to a choice that takes care of me

Paraphrased from Beattie's steps for reacting less (1987).

TRY THIS

Four steps for the moment you feel hooked

- **Notice.** Anxiety, outrage, shame or confusion, and the thought "they made me feel this", often signal that you have been hooked.
- **Settle.** Say and do as little as possible until you are calmer. Breathe, take a walk, call a friend, go to another room.

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TRY THIS (CONT.)

- **Examine.** What actually happened? Am I trying to control something? Am I taking this too personally? Is it truly a disaster, or sad and disappointing?
- **Decide.** From a calmer place, choose what you need to do to take care of yourself, remembering that setting others straight is not your job.

REFLECTION

Describe a recent reaction you later regretted. What was underneath it?

What helps you settle fastest when you are hooked?

Whose reactions do you tend to react to?

PAUSE AND NOTICE

What tends to hook you fastest? What helps you come back to yourself?

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06

SECTION 6

Letting Go of Control

Control promises safety. Letting go is where peace actually begins.

People in codependent patterns often control out of love and fear. If we can just say the right thing, hide the right bottle, make the right rule or worry hard enough, maybe the person we love will change and things will finally be okay. It makes sense. It also rarely works.

Beattie is blunt about this: control is an illusion. We cannot make someone stop drinking, love us, grow up or choose differently. The harder we try, the more the other person tends to resist, and the more exhausted and resentful we become. Meanwhile, the energy we pour into managing someone else is energy taken away from our own lives.

KEY IDEA

Forms control can take

- Advising, reminding, lecturing and checking up.
- Guilt, threats, pleading or tears used to pressure a change.
- Rescuing from consequences so the problem never quite surfaces.
- Helplessness, so that others must step in.
- Managing information: hiding, covering, smoothing things over.

What letting go means

Letting go does not mean we stop caring or stop having preferences. It means we stop trying to force outcomes we cannot force. We state what we want, take care of our part, and release the rest. Many people find comfort in the old recovery phrase "let go and let God", or in the Serenity Prayer's idea of accepting what we cannot change and changing what we can. The only person we can truly control is ourselves.

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TRY THIS

Two lists

Draw a line down a page. On one side, list what you are trying to control in someone else's life. On the other, list what is actually within your power. Circle one item on the first list you are willing to release this week, and one on the second list you will put your energy into instead.

REFLECTION

What do you fear would happen if you stopped trying to control this situation?

Has control ever produced the lasting change you hoped for?

What would you do with the time and energy you get back?

PAUSE AND NOTICE

What are you holding on to most tightly? What might loosening your grip feel like?

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07

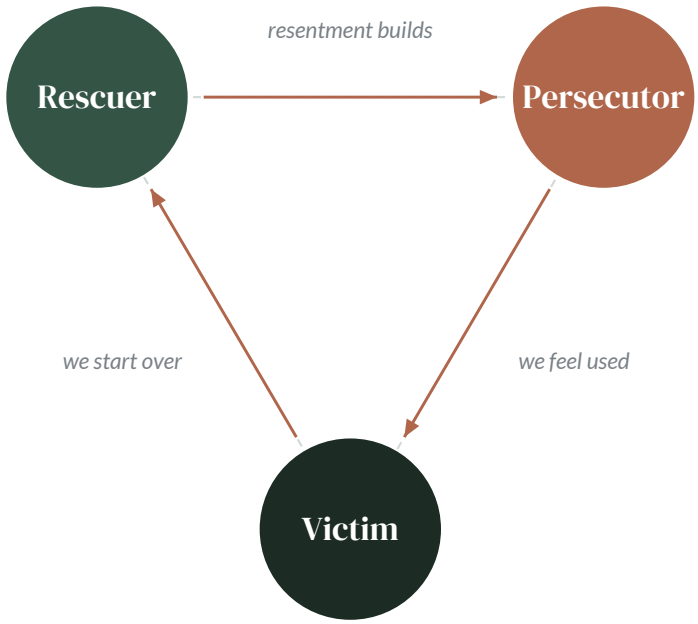
SECTION 7

The Drama Triangle

We are so careful that no one gets hurt, except ourselves.

Beattie describes one pattern as the heart of codependency: rescuing. She draws on psychiatrist Stephen Karpman's **Drama Triangle**, with its three roles of rescuer, persecutor and victim. In her account, people in codependent patterns rescue, then become resentful and persecute, then end up feeling used and victimized, and the loop starts again.

FIGURE 2 THE DRAMA TRIANGLE



RESCUE

We take on what belongs to someone else: saying yes when we mean no, fixing, doing more than our share.

PERSECUTE

Resentment surfaces. We blame, scold, sulk or punish because the help was not appreciated or did not work.

VICTIM

We feel used, hurt and helpless, and often stay stuck there, until the urge to rescue starts the loop again.

Roles from Stephen B. Karpman's Drama Triangle, as applied to caretaking by Beattie (1987).

A **rescue**, in this sense, is any time we take responsibility for another adult's thoughts, feelings, choices, problems or growth. Rescuing is closely related to **enabling**: helping in a way that makes it easier for someone to keep doing something harmful. It usually feels kind in the moment. Beattie points out that it also quietly treats the other person as incapable, and treats ourselves as having no needs.

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KEY IDEA

Signs of a rescue

- Doing something we do not really want to do.
- Saying yes when we mean no.
- Doing for others what they can and should do for themselves.
- Meeting needs before we are asked, or before we have agreed.
- Consistently giving more than we receive.
- Fixing feelings, doing someone's thinking, or speaking for them.
- Absorbing consequences that belong to someone else.
- Not asking for what we want and need.

Stepping off the triangle

The way off the triangle is not to stop helping altogether. It is to help only when we genuinely want to, when the help is truly needed, and when it does not cost us more than we can give. It means letting people solve their own problems and trusting that they can. And it means telling the truth about our own needs, instead of quietly hoping someone will notice.

TRY THIS

Catch the rescue

Over the next week, each time you notice the urge to fix, offer or take over, pause and ask:

- Did they ask? Do I actually want to do this?
- Is this theirs to handle?
- If I do it, will I feel resentful later?
- What would a respectful, not rescuing, response be?

KEY IDEA

Rescuing or genuine help?

- **Rescuing** is driven by anxiety or guilt. **Helping** comes from a free choice.
- **Rescuing** takes over what the other person can do. **Helping** supports what they are already doing.
- **Rescuing** is often unasked. **Helping** usually follows a request and an agreement.

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KEY IDEA (CONT.)

- **Rescuing** leaves us drained and resentful. **Helping** leaves us tired, perhaps, but at peace.
- **Rescuing** keeps the other person small. **Helping** respects their ability to grow.

REFLECTION

Which role on the triangle do you spend the most time in?

Who in your life do you rescue most often? What happens afterward?

What would you need to believe about yourself to stop?

PAUSE AND NOTICE

Where on the triangle do you usually enter? What would stepping off look like?

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08

SECTION 8

Undependence

Needing people is human. Needing them to make us whole is a heavy load for everyone.

Many people in codependent patterns feel that their happiness, safety or sense of worth rests in someone else's hands. If that person is pleased, we are okay. If they leave, pull away or fall apart, so do we. Beattie suggests that this kind of dependence often grows from early experiences of not having enough love, attention or security.

Her answer is not cold independence, but a balanced state she calls **undependence**: being able to rely on ourselves, emotionally and practically, while still enjoying and needing other people. Relationships can then be chosen out of love and want, rather than desperation.

KEY IDEA

What undependence includes

- Recognizing that no one else can be the sole source of our happiness.
- Taking responsibility for our own financial and practical wellbeing, as far as we are able.
- Finding security in ourselves and in a wider circle of support.
- Being able to be alone without panic, and close without disappearing.
- Choosing relationships that add to a life we already value.

Undependence also means facing practical realities. Beattie encourages readers to take responsibility for their own finances and choices, even when that feels frightening. Many people stay in painful patterns partly because they feel unable to stand on their own. Small, steady steps toward self-reliance can bring a surprising sense of freedom.

Based on concepts from Melody Beattie, Codependent No More (1987, 1992). Independent summary; not endorsed by author or publisher.

TRY THIS

An inventory of support

- Who are three people, besides the one I worry about most, I can call?
- What activities bring me comfort or joy, on my own?
- What practical step would make me feel a little more secure?
- Where could I find community: a group, a class, a faith home, a friend?

REFLECTION

Finish the sentence: "I'd be okay if only they would..." What does it tell you?

What would it feel like to need someone, without needing them to save you?

PAUSE AND NOTICE

What is one way you could lean on yourself a little more this week?

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09

SECTION 9

Living Your Own Life

At some point, the question shifts from 'what do they need?' to 'what do I want?'

After years of focusing on someone else, many people find it hard to answer simple questions about themselves. What do I enjoy? What do I want for my future? How am I, really? Beattie encourages readers to take their lives back, one choice at a time: to have hobbies, friendships, plans and pleasures that belong to them.

She also invites us to have a genuine love affair with ourselves. Low self-worth often sits at the root of codependency. We may criticize ourselves constantly, believe we must earn our place by being useful, or feel guilty for wanting anything at all. Self-worth grows as we treat ourselves the way we would treat someone we love.

TRY THIS

Loosening the shoulds

- Notice the rules that run your days: I should always help, I should never be angry, I should be able to fix this.
- Ask where each rule came from, and whether it still serves you.
- Replace a rigid should with a kinder choice: I can help when I want to; I am allowed to feel angry.
- Expect discomfort. Old rules often feel like truth simply because they are familiar.

KEY IDEA

Ways to treat yourself well

- Forgive yourself for mistakes, and for not knowing what you know now.
- Take care of your body: rest, food, movement, medical care.

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KEY IDEA (CONT.)

- Allow yourself to have and express preferences.
- Celebrate small wins and good qualities, in writing if it helps.
- Let others give to you, and practice receiving without apology.

REFLECTION

List ten things you like or enjoy. Which have you not done in a long time?

What should do you most want to let go of?

How do you talk to yourself after a mistake? How would you talk to a friend?

TRY THIS

A small, regular date

Choose one hour this week that belongs only to you. Plan it in advance, protect it as you would an appointment, and spend it on something you enjoy, not something you should do. Afterward, note how you felt.

PAUSE AND NOTICE

What is one want of your own you could take seriously today?

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10

SECTION 10

The Art of Acceptance

Acceptance is not approval. It is the ground we need under our feet before we can choose well.

Acceptance is a theme throughout recovery. Beattie describes it as coming to terms with reality: with who people are, what has happened, and what we can and cannot change. It does not mean liking a situation or giving up on making changes. It means we stop spending our energy pretending, bargaining or fighting the facts, so that we can respond to them.

Coming to acceptance usually involves grief. Beattie applies the stages first described by psychiatrist Elisabeth Kübler-Ross to all kinds of losses: the loss of a relationship as we hoped it would be, the loss of a dream for a child, even the losses that come with positive change. She suggests that many codependent behaviors, such as obsessing and controlling, happen while we are still in denial.

FIGURE 3 HOW WE COME TO ACCEPT A LOSS



Stages after Elisabeth Kübler-Ross, as Beattie applies them to everyday losses and change.

KEY IDEA

Remember about grief

- The stages are a map, not a schedule. We may move back and forth, or feel several at once.

Based on concepts from Melody Beattie, Codependent No More (1987, 1992). Independent summary; not endorsed by author or publisher.

KEY IDEA (CONT.)

- For small losses, the process may take minutes. For large ones, it may take years.
- Feeling confused, lonely or out of control is a normal part of the process, not a sign of failure.
- Acceptance often brings relief and fresh energy to spend on our own lives.

REFLECTION

What loss, large or small, are you grieving right now?

Which stage do you recognize yourself in most often?

What might acceptance make possible for you?

PAUSE AND NOTICE

What reality in your life are you still working to accept? Where are you in that process?

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11

SECTION 11

Feelings and Anger

Feelings are not commands. They are messages worth listening to.

Many people in codependent patterns learned early that feelings were dangerous, inconvenient or selfish. So we became experts at not feeling: staying busy, focusing on others, going numb. Beattie reminds us that feelings do not go away when we ignore them. They tend to come out sideways, as illness, exhaustion, resentment or outbursts.

Feelings are not right or wrong. They are information about what is happening and what matters to us. We do not have to act on every feeling, and we do not have to let feelings run the show. But we do need to feel them. Feeling our feelings is part of taking responsibility for ourselves, instead of waiting for others to change so we can feel better.

TRY THIS

Working with feelings

- Name the feeling, as simply as you can: sad, scared, angry, lonely, glad.
- Notice where it lives in your body.
- Accept it without judgment. It is allowed to be here.
- Ask what it might be telling you about a need or a limit.
- Decide, from a calmer place, whether any action is needed.

Anger

Anger is often the hardest feeling for people in codependent patterns. Beattie lists many myths that keep us stuck: that good people do not get angry, that anger means a relationship is over, that if someone is angry with us we must have done something wrong, or that we have to shout or punish to express it. None of these is true.

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KEY IDEA

Healthier ways with anger

- Let yourself feel it. It is energy, and it will pass.
- Look at the thoughts that come with it, and test them against reality.
- Take responsibility for it: "I feel angry when..." rather than "You made me..."
- Talk with someone you trust, or write a letter you do not send.
- Burn off the physical energy safely: walk, clean, exercise.
- Notice anger as a signal that a limit has been crossed, and decide what you will do.

REFLECTION

What did you learn about anger growing up?

Which myths about anger do you still believe, at least a little?

Is there an old anger you have been carrying? What would help you release it safely?

PAUSE AND NOTICE

What feeling have you been avoiding? What might it be trying to tell you?

Based on concepts from Melody Beattie, Codependent No More (1987, 1992). Independent summary; not endorsed by author or publisher.

12

SECTION 12

Thinking, Goals and Speaking Up

Your mind, your wants and your words are worth trusting.

Worry and obsession can leave us feeling as though we cannot think clearly. Some of us were told, directly or indirectly, that our thoughts did not matter. Beattie encourages readers to treat their minds with care: to rest them from worry, feed them with good information and use them to make decisions and form opinions.

KEY IDEA

Caring for your mind

- Give your mind some peace. Detach and calm down before making decisions.
- Gather information rather than guessing or assuming.
- Stop calling yourself stupid or incapable.
- Make decisions, small and large, and let yourself learn from them.
- Stretch your mind with something new: reading, a class, a project.

Setting goals

People who spend their energy on others often lose track of what they want. Beattie suggests turning wants and problems into goals, writing them down, and then letting go of the timing. Goals give life direction and help us notice that we are moving forward, even slowly.

TRY THIS

A goal-setting practice

- Write down what you want, without editing for what you should want.
- Include all areas: work, money, health, relationships, play, growth.
- Turn a problem into a goal: "I want a calmer evening routine."

Based on concepts from Melody Beattie, Codependent No More (1987, 1992). Independent summary; not endorsed by author or publisher.

TRY THIS (CONT.)

- Do one small thing toward a goal each day, then let the rest be.
- Check off goals as you reach them, and set new ones.

Speaking clearly

Communication in codependent relationships often runs through hints, blame, silence or saying what we think the other person wants to hear. Beattie encourages a different approach: say what you mean, mean what you say, and say it without cruelty. Clear communication includes being able to say no, ask for what you need and express feelings without demanding that the other person change.

IN YOUR OWN WORDS

In your own words

- "No, I'm not able to do that."
- "I'd like some help with this."
- "I feel hurt when plans change at the last minute."
- "I'm not going to discuss this while you're drinking."
- "I need some time to think before I answer."
- "That's your decision to make."

REFLECTION

What is one thing you have been hinting at instead of saying directly?

Which goal would make the biggest difference this year?

Based on concepts from Melody Beattie, Codependent No More (1987, 1992). Independent summary; not endorsed by author or publisher.

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SECTION 13

Support and Recovery

We do not have to do this alone, and we do not have to do it perfectly.

Beattie strongly recommends support groups, especially Twelve Step groups such as Al-Anon, Nar-Anon and Co-Dependents Anonymous (CoDA). These groups offer a place to speak honestly, hear from people with similar experiences and practice new ways of living. Many people find that simply being understood brings enormous relief.

The Twelve Steps invite participants to admit powerlessness over other people, to turn to a power greater than themselves, to take an honest inventory, to make amends where appropriate, and to carry the message to others. People interpret the spiritual language in many ways. Others prefer therapy groups, secular support groups or trusted friends. What matters is connection.

KEY IDEA

Recovery reminders

- One day at a time. We only have to take care of ourselves today.
- Easy does it. Change happens gradually.
- Progress, not perfection.
- Let go and let God, or let things unfold in their own time.
- HALT: try not to make big decisions when Hungry, Angry, Lonely or Tired.

When old patterns return

Beattie is honest that recovery has slips. Under stress, we may find ourselves rescuing, controlling or obsessing again. This is normal. A relapse is not a failure, but a sign to return to what helps: detaching, feeling our feelings, reaching out and caring for ourselves. Over time, we notice sooner and recover faster.

Based on concepts from Melody Beattie, Codependent No More (1987, 1992). Independent summary; not endorsed by author or publisher.

KEY IDEA

Early warning signs

- Thinking more and more about someone else's behavior.
- Withdrawing from friends, groups or activities you enjoy.
- Saying yes when you mean no, then feeling resentful.
- Neglecting sleep, food or rest.
- Feeling hopeless or sorry for yourself much of the time.

Learning to love again

Near the end of her book, Beattie turns to relationships. Recovery does not mean giving up on love. It means learning to love without losing ourselves: staying connected to our own feelings, limits and lives while caring about someone else. Healthy love includes both closeness and separateness.

REFLECTION

What kind of support would feel most comfortable to try first?

Which warning signs show up first for you?

What would a relationship look like in which you could be fully yourself?

PAUSE AND NOTICE

Where could you find people who understand? What small step could you take toward them?

Based on concepts from Melody Beattie, Codependent No More (1987, 1992). Independent summary; not endorsed by author or publisher.

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SECTION 14

Daily Practice

Small, steady habits help you come back to your own life.

TRY THIS

A five-minute morning check-in

1. **Arrive.** Feel your feet and your breath. Notice how you slept.
2. **Notice.** What am I feeling? What am I worried about?
3. **Sort.** Which of these worries are mine to act on today, and which belong to someone else?
4. **Choose.** What is one thing I want for myself today?
5. **Release.** Name one thing you will let go of, at least for today.

TRY THIS

An evening review

- Where did I take care of myself today?
- Where did I rescue, control or react? What was underneath it?
- What feeling showed up most?
- What will I try differently tomorrow?
- What am I grateful for today?

IN YOUR OWN WORDS

Everyday phrases

- "That's not mine to fix."
- "I can care without carrying."

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IN YOUR OWN WORDS (CONT.)

- "My feelings are information, not orders."
- "I can let go of the outcome."
- "I'm allowed to want things."
- "I'll take care of myself first, and then decide."

REFLECTION

For the coming weeks

Describe your life five years from now if you were taking good care of yourself.

Write about a time you let someone handle their own problem. What did you learn?

List the people and places that help you feel most like yourself.

What limit, kindly held, would protect your peace the most right now?

Finish the sentence: "If I didn't need them to change, I would..."

TRY THIS

A weekly look back

Once a week, set aside fifteen minutes to look over your check-ins and evening reviews. You are looking for patterns, not grading yourself.

- Which situations or people hooked me most often this week?
- When did I detach, let go or say no, even a little? How did it feel?

Based on concepts from Melody Beattie, Codependent No More (1987, 1992). Independent summary; not endorsed by author or publisher.

TRY THIS (CONT.)

- What did I do just for me?
- Which section of this workbook do I want to reread next week?

SAFETY

Grounding when it's too much

- Press your feet into the floor and lengthen your exhale.
- Name five things you see and three you can hear.
- Remind yourself that you are safe in this moment, if you are.
- Reach out to someone safe, or call or text 988 if you are in crisis.

KEY IDEA

Signs you are healing

- You notice the urge to rescue and pause before acting.
- Someone else's bad day no longer ruins yours.
- You can say no without a long explanation.
- You have plans and pleasures of your own.
- You feel your feelings and let them pass.
- You treat yourself with the care you give to others.

PAUSE AND NOTICE

Looking back over this workbook, what is one thing you want to carry forward?

Based on concepts from Melody Beattie, Codependent No More (1987, 1992). Independent summary; not endorsed by author or publisher.

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SECTION 15

For Therapists

Using these ideas in session, with care.

CLINICIAN NOTE: FOUNDATIONS

Stance and framing

- Offer psychoeducation early. Naming caretaking, control and detachment often reduces shame and confusion.
- Frame codependent patterns as adaptive responses learned in difficult systems, not character flaws.
- Validate the love and loyalty underneath the pattern while helping clients see its costs.
- Watch for caretaking of the therapist, deference and difficulty naming needs in session.

CLINICIAN NOTE: IN SESSION

Interventions

- Use the Drama Triangle to map recent interactions and identify entry points and exits.
- Practice the notice, settle, examine, decide sequence for reactivity, and rehearse scripts for saying no.
- Explore the shoulds, internalized rules and the family-of-origin roots of caretaking.
- Support grief work around accepting a loved one's addiction, illness or limits.
- Encourage connection to support groups as an adjunct, respecting client values about spiritual language.

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SAFETY (TIST)

Safety and risk

- Screen for depression, anxiety, trauma symptoms, substance use and suicidality. Use standard risk assessment and safety planning, including 988.
- Assess for intimate partner violence. Detachment and limit-setting can increase risk in abusive relationships, so safety planning comes first.
- Avoid pressuring clients to leave or stay; support informed, self-directed choices.

CLINICIAN NOTE: KEEP IN MIND

Cautions

- "Codependency" is a popular and descriptive term, not a DSM diagnosis. Avoid using it as a label in records.
- The concept has been critiqued for pathologizing caregiving and for gender bias; hold it lightly and use it collaboratively.
- The book reflects addiction-recovery culture of its time. Supplement it with current evidence-based approaches as indicated.

CLINICIAN NOTE: CREDIT

Source

Based on concepts from Melody Beattie, *Codependent No More: How to Stop Controlling Others and Start Caring for Yourself* (Center City, MN: Hazelden, 1987; 2nd ed. 1992). This workbook summarizes and paraphrases the book's ideas in original language for educational use. It is not affiliated with or endorsed by the author or publisher, and it is not a substitute for therapy.

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SECTION 16

Glossary

Key terms in plain language.

Based on concepts from Melody Beattie, Codependent No More (1987, 1992). Independent summary; not endorsed by author or publisher.

Acceptance. Coming to terms with what is real, so we can respond to it rather than fight it. Not the same as approval.

Al-Anon. A Twelve Step fellowship for people affected by someone else's drinking.

Caretaking. Taking responsibility for others' feelings, choices and problems, often at our own expense.

CoDA. Co-Dependents Anonymous, a Twelve Step group focused on codependent patterns.

Codependency. Letting another person's behavior affect us deeply, and becoming preoccupied with controlling it.

Control. Trying to make people or events turn out a certain way through pressure, guilt, rescuing or worry.

Denial. Not seeing, or minimizing, a painful reality. Often the first stage of grief.

Detachment. Releasing, with love, from entanglement in another person's problems and responsibilities.

Drama Triangle. Karpman's model of three roles, rescuer, persecutor and victim, that people cycle through.

Enabling. Helping in a way that makes it easier for someone to continue harmful behavior.

Grief process. The stages people move through to accept a loss: denial, anger, bargaining, sadness, acceptance.

HALT. A reminder to pause when Hungry, Angry, Lonely or Tired.

Higher Power. In Twelve Step language, a power greater than oneself, understood in one's own way.

Letting go. Releasing our grip on outcomes we cannot control, while still caring.

Obsession. Repetitive worry and thinking about other people and their problems.

Persecutor. The role in which resentment turns into blame, criticism or punishment.

Reacting. Responding automatically and intensely, often handing our power to whatever set us off.

Relapse. A return to old patterns under stress. A signal to return to self-care, not a failure.

Rescuer. The role of fixing, saving or taking over for someone who can care for themselves.

Self-worth. A basic sense that we matter and deserve care, regardless of how useful we are.

Shoulds. Rigid inner rules about how we must act and feel, often learned early.

Twelve Steps. A recovery program, first developed by Alcoholics Anonymous, adapted by many groups.

Undependence. Relying on ourselves for security while still enjoying and needing others.

Victim. The role of feeling used, helpless and stuck, often after a rescue goes wrong.

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